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W E D N E S D A Y , S E P T E M B E R 2 3 , 2 0 2 6

Election nearing, Healey shifts on gas tax

Calls for a two-month halt after opposing for years; Minogue had called for ‘holiday’

By Kelly Garrity
and Anjali Huynh
GLOBE STAFF

For years, Governor Maura Healey has rejected the idea of suspending the state gas tax when the price at the pump was especially painful, echoing lawmakers and finance experts who saw such a move as a threat to the state’s financial footing.

Six weeks out from the general election, she’s changing her mind. Healey on Tuesday proposed in-

stituting a two-month moratorium on the 24-cents-a-gallon tax on gas and diesel, just days after her Republican opponent, Michael Minogue, called for a more sweeping “gas tax holiday” whenever prices top \$4 a gallon. Minogue is also undating the airways with commercials where he makes his pitch next to a gas pump as part of the former Abiomed executive’s seven-figure ad buy.

The GOP candidate, who trailed Healey by 25 percentage points in a

June Suffolk University/Boston Globe poll, was all too happy to paint Healey’s call to suspend the gas tax as politically motivated.

“She’s going to push everything to right after the election and go back to overtaxing our people right after the election,” he said outside the State House on Tuesday. “I’m glad she’s taking the lead, but unfortunately, she’s only planning to do it for two months. So after the election, it will be back to business as normal.”

The candidates’ dueling proposals come as gas prices have surged amid war in the Middle East, pushing gas to \$4.40 a gallon and diesel

to \$6.39 a gallon in Massachusetts as of Tuesday, according to AAA. Healey said Tuesday that her proposal, which her office estimated would cost the state about \$120 million, would be offset by using higher-than-expected revenue from the state’s surtax on high-income earners.

“This is a responsible thing to do, a necessary thing to do,” the first-term Democrat said at a news conference at the State House on Tuesday.

The proposal, however, not only drew the expected criticism from her Republican opponent, but im-

GAS, Page A10

MCAS scores still down across the board

High school English drop raises questions on prep

By Christopher Huffaker
and John Hilliard
GLOBE STAFF

Massachusetts student achievement has continued to decline on state tests, with Grade 10 English scores posting a particularly steep slide, according to MCAS results released Monday.

The findings show that students have not only failed to regain ground lost during the pandemic, but also have demonstrated little, if any, improvement since last year.

Slumping test scores spanned nearly all student demographics and school district types, from affluent suburbs to lower-income urban districts, stretching from Duxbury to Pittsfield. State Education Commissioner Pedro Martinez offered a blunt assessment of student achievement when he spoke Monday at a press briefing.

“We’re still not where we want to be,” Martinez said, “in terms of our results.”

Across the state, children in grades 3 to 8 scored on average about the same as their predecessors last year in math, while English results only slid slightly. But scores on both tests were far below pre-pandemic levels.

The drop in high school English scores year over year was much more significant. With MCAS no longer a graduation requirement, the results raised questions of whether high school students are less prepared academically or merely less motivated to do well on the test.

On the English exam, the share of 10th-graders meeting expectations fell by 6 points for a second year in a row, to 45 percent. Just five years ago, more than 60 percent of students passed the

MCAS, Page A7



PHOTOS BY CRAIG F. WALKER/GLOBE STAFF

The South Boston Street Fest was held last weekend. Few neighborhoods have an array of income levels.

In South Boston, the line is drawn

Vast income disparities are worsening, further dividing the rich and poor

By Katie Johnston
GLOBE STAFF

In a 1-mile stretch of South Boston, the city’s vast income disparities collide. The shimmering high-rises of the Seaport stand at one end, and just across West Broadway, block after block of three-story brick housing developments are on the other.

Southie resident John Meier sees the vast socioeconomic divide in the young professionals who pay a premium to get groceries delivered from Whole Foods just blocks away from residents who rely on food pantries to feed their families.

It really hit home for Meier, 43, a decade ago when he found out one of his high school students lived in a public housing complex near him. When he told the student they were neighbors, Meier recalled, “He laughed and said, ‘I’m not your neighbor.’”

West Broadway marks the dividing line between the affluent, where the median family income is more than \$250,000, and the underprivileged, where it’s just \$60,000. It’s one of the starkest contrasts in Greater Boston, which is among the

SOUTH BOSTON, Page A10



The Rev. Burns Stanfield, pastor of Fourth Presbyterian Church, mourns the loss of school-age children as parents leave for the suburbs.

With fantasy football, Commish really rules

BETH TEITELL

The tweet came from an account on X that usually gets one or two likes per post, tops. But then, a few days into the NFL season, a formerly private citizen named Harrison Hughes tapped into a matter so raw, so profound — of such cultural importance — that he went viral.

“It’s kinda [messed] up that teachers get paid more than Fantasy Football Commissioners,” wrote Hughes, 30, a sales executive at an AI company.

The love came fast. “Commissioners need to start a union,” read one popular response. “Completely thankless job,” read another.

There may be no harder gig in America than fantasy football commissioner — at least according to the commissioners.

There are approximately 40 million

FANTASY, Page A6

Mistakes are made as marketing speeds up

Issues of judgment may reflect ad agencies’ struggles to keep pace

By Alexa Gagosz
GLOBE STAFF

The outcry over Converse’s latest social media ad from critics who said it echoed Ku Klux Klan iconography is just the latest in a recent string of advertising controversies that all follow a similar pattern: mounting criticism, the hurried apology, and the pledge to be better.

“We’re sorry,” said Converse, owned by Nike, in a statement. “We understand why this image is deeply upsetting and recognize that we got this wrong.”

“This should not have happened and we will do better,” added the company, which pulled the ad from its channels.

It all sounded rather familiar.

From a controversial Callaway golf commercial depicting violence against women to a Sydney Sweeney sports-betting campaign criticized for its portrayal of women, quite a few brands of

late have had to beg forgiveness for ads that left many wondering how on Earth multiple layers of creative and corporate review allowed such a thing to go public.

The answer, some experts say, may have less to do with one person making a bad call than with the hurried way modern advertising gets made amid the brutal pace of social media.

Yanique DaCosta, a brand development consultant and president of the Graphic Artists Guild who has worked on corporate creative for Apple, Google, Hilton, and Marriott, said advertising teams are producing more work on tighter deadlines, with each department often reviewing only its own piece of the campaign, not

CONVERSE, Page A7



JONATHAN WIGGS/GLOBE STAFF

Converse, with headquarters in Boston, has seen its revenues tumble over the past two years. The pulled ad with KKK connotations could hurt the brand.



Falling for it

Wednesday: Breezy, pleasant. High 61-66. Low 50-55.

Thursday: More of the same. High 60-65. Low 52-57.
High tide: 9:39 a.m., 9:49 p.m.
Sunrise: 6:32 Sunset: 6:40

Weather and Comics, G6-7.

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